THE U-BOAT WAR 1939–45

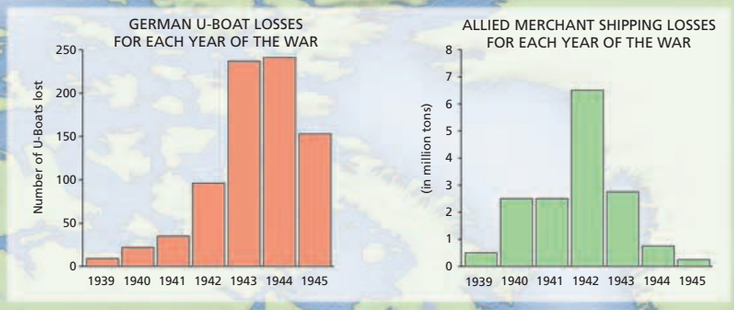
FROM SUMMER 1940 TO SPRING 1943 German U-boats, led by Admiral Karl Dönitz, attempted to blockade Britain into submission by sinking convoys of merchant ships carrying much needed supplies across the Atlantic. Operating from bases in occupied Brittany, the U-boats attacked escorted convoys in groups known as "wolf packs." The period up to February 1941 became known as the "Happy Time" for U-boat crews, as British convoy escorts were inadequate in numbers, equipment, and training, and the U-boats sank many ships. Successful U-boat captains became celebrated in Germany as "aces." A second surge of U-boat success followed the entry of the United States into the war in December 1941, which allowed them to prey on ships on convoy routes up and down the US east coast. The climax of the U-boat war came in spring 1943. Just as Dönitz looked like winning the war, a combination of superior industrial production, improved technology and tactics, air cover, and intelligence allowed the Allies to turn the tide decisively against the U-boats. Overall, the U-boat war was exceptionally tough for Allied merchant and naval seamen, whether crossing the Atlantic or on the harsh Arctic route to Russia. However, it was the U-boat crews that suffered the heaviest losses, with 60 percent of all crew dying during the war.

THE U-BOAT WAR 1940–1943

The main areas of engagement between German and Allied forces during the U-boat war were in the North Atlantic along the major convoy routes connecting the US east coast with the UK, and along the convoys routes running around the US east coast. German U-boat wolfpacks also targeted Allied merchant shipping on routes running through the Arctic between the UK and northern Russia, and on convoys running between West Africa and the UK and from the Americas through the Straits of Gibraltar into the Mediterranean.

KEY

- Allied territory 1942
- Axis territory 1942
- Major convoy route 1943
- Maximum extent of air cover 1940
- Maximum extent of air cover 1943
- U-boat base
- 1 Main areas of U-boat success Jun 1940–Mar 1941
- 2 Main areas of U-boat success Jan 1942–Feb 1943
- 3 Main areas of U-boat success Mar–Sep 1943



GREENLAND
Spitzbergen
Jul 2–13,1942: North Sea convoy PQ-17 suffers severe losses to U-boats and Luftwaffe after convoy is ordered to disperse
to Arkhangelsk
Summer route to USSR
Winter route to USSR
May 1943: "Black May" Germans lose 41 U-boats. Dönitz recalls wolf packs from North Atlantic. They return in Sep 1943, but can never repeat their earlier success
May 1940: British troops occupy Iceland. Replaced by US troops in Jul 1941
Tromso
Narvik
Oct 9,1939: Günther Prien, in U-47, penetrates British naval base at Scapa Flow and sinks battleship *Royal Oak*
SWEDEN
ICELAND
Trondheim
FINLAND
16–20 Mar,1943: Convoys SC-122 and HX-229 attacked by three wolf packs (41 U-boats), which sink 22 ships (146,000 tons)
Oct 1940: Convoy SC-7 from Nova Scotia to Liverpool attacked by pack of seven U-boats. Only 12 out of 34 ships make it to port
Bergen
NORWAY
1
Scapa Flow
North Sea
May 1943: Convoy ONS-5 attacked by over 40 U-boats. Despite loss of 12 merchantmen, escorts sink six U-boats and inflict serious damage on seven others
Londonderry
UNITED KINGDOM
DENMARK
Bremen
Kiel
Berlin
Moscow
USSR
CANADA
Jun 1941: Britain starts providing escorts for full length of North Atlantic convoy crossings. Royal Canadian Navy assumes responsibility for western zone from base at St John's, Newfoundland
Liverpool
London
GERMANY
Mar 15–17,1941: Inbound convoy HX-112 attacked by five U-boats. Five ships (50,000 tons) lost, but U-boats of two of Germany's leading aces, Joachim Schepke and Otto Kretschmer, sunk
NEWFOUNDLAND
St John's
Brest
Paris
Lorient
St Nazaire
FRANCE
SWITZ.
Jun 1940: New U-boat bases on France's Atlantic coast become operational. Start of first "Happy Time" for U-boat crews
La Rochelle
ROMANIA
Sydney
Halifax
3
ITALY
YUGOSLAVIA
BULGARIA
Rome
PORT.
SPAIN
UNITED STATES
New York
July 19,1942: U-boats withdrawn from US east coast. Operations switched to mid-Atlantic
Azores
August 1943: Allies acquire use of the Azores as airbase
TURKEY
GREECE
SPANISH MOROCCO
Gibraltar
Jan 13,1942: Start of Operation *Paukenschlag* (Drumbeat). Following American entry into the war, Germans redirect U-boat operations to unescorted convoys off US east coast. Start of second "Happy Time"
FRENCH MOROCCO
Alexandria
Cairo
Houston
New Orleans
2
ALGERIA
LIBYA
EGYPT
Gulf of Mexico
Miami
CUBA
MEXICO
2
FRENCH WEST AFRICA
Caribbean Sea
ATLANTIC OCEAN
SUDAN
NICARAGUA
FRENCH EQUATORIAL AFRICA
VENEZUELA
Freetown
NIGERIA
Lagos
BRITISH GUIANA
2
SIERRA LEONE
LIBERIA
GOLD COAST
COLOMBIA
FRENCH GUIANA
CAMEROON
DUTCH GUIANA
ECUADOR
BELGIAN CONGO
PERU
BRAZIL
N
0 km 1000
0 miles 1000